

AP PHOTO/US AIRCRAFT

WARM UP:
Ahmadinejad with
Manmohan at the
PM's residence



An Evening in Delhi

Iranian President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad's brief visit to India puts an end to the uncertainty in the relationship between the two countries but the road ahead remains bumpy

■ **By Saurabh Shukla**

For the 52-year-old former revolutionary guard-turned-Iranian President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad—increasingly isolated and dubbed a global pariah—the short trip to India was more about hidden diplomatic messages than a wholesome agenda. Faced with mounting US-led international pressure to abandon his nuclear ambitions, it was a trip for the embattled Iranian hardliner to seek a shoulder to lean on, by reaching out to friendly countries like India to solicit their support.

So after several months of uncertainty, with India in a dilemma over when to schedule his visit, when finally Ahmadinejad landed in Delhi on a hot April 29 afternoon, the tour had many firsts—it was his first visit to India and also one of the shortest diplomatic-level visits by any world leader to India.

Ahmadinejad's trip was a way of telling the world that he still had some credible backers in the international community, like India, which were keen to do business with the sultan of the "evil axis". For India too, the visit served the UPA Government politically as it helped correct the perception that

in its quest for a nuclear deal with the US and a strategic relationship with Washington, India had mortgaged its foreign policy. Even though India and the US did exchange some barbs over America's suggestions on how India should be dealing with Iran, much of it seemed a part of well calibrated stage-managed diplomacy aimed at pushing the Indo-US nuclear deal. Ahmadinejad's visit also sends a strong message to the Muslims in the country that India is not clipping its engagement with the Islamic world, which is crucial for the Government especially with the key state elections scheduled